

film review Only Sound, No Spirit

THE LAST LEAR

Rating: ★☆☆☆☆

Director: Rituparno Ghosh

Starring: Amitabh Bachchan, Preity Zinta

"Oberon", says the actor with the unmistakable baritone. "Oberoi," writes the boyish journalist, an appropriate frown of concentration on his unlined brow. They are sitting in the actor's shabbily genteel room. "Robin," tries the actor, again. "Robin Hood?" offers the journalist. "Bloody idiot," erupts the actor. It's *Midsummer Night's Dream*, of course, and the Shakespearean actor is insulted by the young pup who has come to interview him. It's one of the more enjoyable



DREARY LEAR: Amitabh Bachchan and Arjun Rampal

exchanges in Ghosh's somewhat dreary *The Last Lear*. As a film about an ageing actor given his first shot at performing onscreen, adapted from the late great Utpal Dutt's play, Ghosh has a gem of an idea. And an immaculate jewel in his crown, Bachchan. What he doesn't have is a crackling screenplay, as the story me-

anders from a declamation on modern Indian cinema to an exercise in female bonding. Surprisingly for Ghosh, usually considered a "woman's" director, the relationship between the actor and the director (played by Arjun Rampal) who wants to hire him is first rate. The actor is prickly, sarcastic and an endless source of dry

humour. The director is suitably calm. "I want your show reel, some samples of your acting," he says to the actor. "You get samples in a fabric shop, young man," declares the actor. Both end up buddies, swilling gin and watching passers-by pee on the boundary wall. Bachchan is in full flight, using his flawless English diction as well as his commanding presence, allowing himself to ham gloriously. But the movie moves with leaden feet, clomping heavily from the living room to bedroom, and then stomping noisily in a hill station where the actor takes a young model-turned-actor under his wings. She weeps on his shoulder, makes him tea and purses up her lips when an autograph hunter doesn't know who he is. Unfortunately, by the end of the film, even we don't care.

by Kaveree Bamzai

FORTUNE

Chariot Beach Resort

Fortune Chariot Beach Resort is the latest corporate destination for conferences and training by the likes of ABN Amro, Axis Bank, Cathay Pacific, Coca-Cola, Cognizant, Dr. Reddy's Lab, E&Y, HCL, India Today, Kingfisher, Nokia, Times of India, Titan & World Bank. Having the LARGEST swimming pool on the East Coast is just one of the reasons why Chariot is the preferred one.

For booking Call 94449 92701 / 044 - 2466 0180 www.chariotbeachresorts.com

FORTUNE

Chariot Beach Resort

BY WELCOMGROUP

Mahabalipuram

Five Rathas Road, Behind Five Rathas Monument, Mahabalipuram, Chennai - 603104 Tel: 044-2742500, 39884411 Cell: 9444992727 email: resv@chariotbeachresorts.com